

# THE KARAT DOGMA

Even when defending the nation, the Indian communist invokes an enemy as fake as his ideology

■ By S. Prasannarajan

It is stranger than the fiction called *Das Kapital*, and it is happening in the strangest of Soviets in the mythology of communism. India, whose democracy continues to be cited in varying degrees of exclamation whenever the limits of civil society are in focus, has become the land where the last fighters of an ideology are out there in the streets in the name of—surprise, surprise!—national interest. Students of the spectral science known as socialism may find here the final proof for the death of irony, but then, this is an Indian story and the protagonists are comrades of archival vintage. India, communists, and national interest—can we really go any farther in the dialectics of absurdity? And look who's in the vanguard of the "national" struggle of liberation, armed with arguments whose victory can only take us back to an updated version of *juche*, the spirit of self-reliance as institutionalised in the glorious hermit kingdom of North Korea. It is Prakash Karat, the chief apparatchik of Indian communists, rhapsodised in certain idolatry sections of the media as the second most important politico in the country, as the nationalist in rage.

Courtesy the nuclear deal, we have at last the Comrade-Nationalist on full display. Stripped of its rusty rhetoric, Karat's nationalism—or his idea of national interest—is a fantasy as self-deluding as his ideology. For, the Indian communists, despite the number of MPs, lost the nation long ago, unless the nation is the sum total of the sub-rural Soviets of West Bengal and Kerala. They lost the class war as well as the caste war; India defied them. Even in their two trophy states, the party in power is a provincial appara-

tus with the worst instincts of intimidation. Still, in Delhi, it is the interests of the nation that concentrate the mind of the resident commissar of AKG Bhavan. Well, you may argue that it's a Chinese inspiration. In the Middle Kingdom, it is a ruthless form of national interest that passes off as "socialism with Chinese characteristics". It is capitalism with social pre-

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tence, sustained by Leninist prisons, where Mao is a bestseller only in the souvenir shop, and where the Big Mac is consumed more than Big Marx. It was Deng's selective Americanism—capital, yes, but democracy, no—that made the Chinese makeover a market thriller in national interest, in spite of the still-functional Chinese gulags.

Karat's national interest, in practice, is closer to the Hugo Chavez variety. The Venezuelan demagogue who aspires to be the Castro of the 21st century has made anti-Americanism a necessary condition for the pursuit of national interest. He has made a career out of it. Still, there is a difference. Karat plays out his anti-Americanism in a country he has not won. He has acquired—rather borrowed—the book, the slogan, but not India. He has no empire to build—or to lose. He, though, enjoys the prerogative of political harlotry: power without responsibility. To put that prerogative in action, he needs the enemy, a bogeyman who can be paraded across the ghettos of illiteracy and minority paranoia. He has got anti-Americanism, though it is an ism that has already been made redundant by the impulses of civil societies, India included. (Well, the most articulate anti-Americans say it with an American accent.) Even when it comes to defending the nation, the Indian communist has to invoke an enemy as fake as his ideology. Maybe, other enemies, real and immediate, have failed him. They—the so-called communalists, casteists and capitalists—have made India a nation inaccessible to the communist. They have won the war—and the nation. Anti-Americanism is the last slogan of the desperate revolutionary, and Karat makes sense only in his ideological desperation.

The India that dawns in the fantasy of the Indian communist is so remote from the India that indulges comrades like Prakash Karat. National interest will be better served when Indian communists liberate themselves from the lies that have been abandoned by history. ■